

Practice Paper 34 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “The city belonged almost entirely to Mr Tan”

Award **1 mark** for recognising that the streets are nearly **deserted** / **empty** at this hour; **1 mark** for explaining that, because almost no one else is awake or moving, Mr Tan has the streets **all to himself**.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that the streets are **almost completely empty** of other people at this hour, so that Mr Tan, being one of the very few people up and about, feels as though the whole city is **his own** private space.

Q2. [2] — “As solitary as a lamp post”

1 mark — A lamp post stands **alone**, **unmoving**, and **unnoticed** on a street; the comparison suggests Mr Tan is **deeply lonely** and **taken for granted** by passers-by.

1 mark — It also suggests he has become so much a part of the street furniture that, like a lamp post, he is **barely noticed** by anyone — a quiet, fixed presence rather than a person with companions.

Q3. [2] — Two details showing Mr Tan finds peace at this hour

1 mark each for any two of:

- The streetlights make “small, kindly pools” on the pavement (a comforting image).
- The air “smelled of nothing in particular” — clean, neutral, undisturbed.
- The day shift’s “exhaust fumes” and “sharp commercial smells” have not yet arrived.
- He “treasured these dawn rounds” because they “asked nothing of him beyond what he already gave.”

Reject: mere lifting of “he liked this hour” without elaboration.

Q4. [2] — Setting down the broom carefully

1 mark — He is suddenly **focused** / **alert**: he treats the broom as if it were **fragile or precious**, indicating that his attention has shifted entirely to the new sound.

1 mark — It suggests **delicacy and care** even before he knows what he has found — he does not want to make any noise that might **frighten** whatever is making the sound.

Q5. [2] — The kitten’s eyes “no larger than coffee beans”

(a) **[1]**: The comparison suggests the kitten is **extremely small** / **tiny** / **vulnerable** — its eyes are no bigger than a small everyday bean.

(b) **[1]**: An **everyday** object (a coffee bean) keeps the description **grounded, gentle, and unsentimental**; it suits the quiet, ordinary world of Mr Tan and avoids exaggerated emotion. (Also accept: it makes the kitten feel **familiar** and **real** rather than dramatised.)

Q6. [3] — Unusual tenderness (language question)

1 mark for identifying **tenderness** / **care** / **parental gentleness**; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “All right, all right” / “Don’t be afraid” — he speaks aloud to the kitten “as if calming a frightened child”, suggesting a parental tone.
- “lowered himself onto his knees on the wet kerb, ignoring the cold” — he willingly suffers discomfort for the kitten’s sake.
- “He waited so long that his shoulder began to ache” — his patience is striking for a man unused to handling small creatures.
- “with extraordinary care, around a body no bigger than a bread roll” — **extraordinary** underlines the unusual gentleness.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — Two heartbeats together

1 mark for understanding **connection** / **shared rhythm** — the kitten’s small heartbeat is felt against Mr Tan’s own, forming a **quiet bond** between them.

1 mark for the **symbolic** suggestion — that something **living and frightened** has, in this instant, been **calmed by him**, and that Mr Tan, too, is being affected by the encounter.

Q8. [1] — “Less than a packet of dried noodles”

1 mark — The **humble, everyday** comparison shows Mr Tan thinking of the kitten in terms of **his own ordinary kitchen** — he is already, almost unconsciously, **imagining it in his home**. (Also accept: it shows **protective awareness** of how **light** and **fragile** the kitten is.)

Q9. [1] — Evidence he has decided to keep it

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- “he picked up his broom with his free hand... and turned for home” (he is going home, not to the shelter).
- He thinks of the shelter and the rules “the way a man thinks of weather he intends to ignore”.

- “He had a half-tin of sardines in the cupboard. He had, he supposed, a saucer somewhere” — he is already planning to feed it.

Q10. [2] — “Something inside him... how to be tender”

1 mark — Mr Tan has **rediscovered a capacity for affection and care** that he had not used for a long time — perhaps for years of solitary life.

1 mark — The change is **sudden and unexpected** (“all at once”) — a single small encounter has **reawakened** a part of him he had forgotten he possessed.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **tender, quietly hopeful, gentle, reflective, warm**. (Reject: **triumphant, sad** — these miss the soft, quietly changed quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — Why crying is “peculiar”

1 mark each for any two of:

- We cry both when we are **sad** and when we are **happy / overjoyed** (the same act for opposite feelings).
- We cry at **art** — violin concertos, novels — not only at personal events.
- No other species appears to produce **emotional** tears in the way humans do.

Q13. [2] — Basal vs reflex tears (own words)

1 mark — **Basal** tears are produced **continuously** to **keep the eye healthy and lubricated** and to wash away dust.

1 mark — **Reflex** tears are produced **only when something irritates the eye** (e.g. onions, smoke), to flush the irritant out.

Reject answers that lift “bathes the eye” or “flush the irritant” without rewording.

Q14. [1] — Why distinguish emotional tears chemically

1 mark — The writer is suggesting that emotional tears may have a **different biological purpose** from the other two kinds — they are not just lubrication or irritation, but something **unique to human feeling**.

Q15. [2] — “Suggestive but not yet settled”

1 mark — **Suggestive**: the evidence **hints** that emotional tears may have a chemical function (e.g. removing stress hormones).

1 mark — **Not yet settled**: this idea has **not been firmly proven** — controlled studies have not yet confirmed that crying leaves a person chemically calmer.

Q16. [2] — Why “unusually visible” eyes matter

1 mark — Because humans have an unusually **large white area (sclera)** around the iris, **small movements and moisture** on the eye are **very easy for other people to see**.

1 mark — This visibility is essential to the writer’s argument: tears can only act as a **social signal** if other people can **easily notice** them; the human eye seems almost **designed** to let others see when we cry.

Q17. [2] — Effect of “I am not coping; please come closer”

1 mark — The **first-person voice** gives the tear an imagined **human speech**, making the reader feel the **vulnerability** behind the act of crying.

1 mark — It makes the **function of tears feel personal and emotional**, rather than coldly biological — tears are a **plea for help and connection**. (Accept also: the **short, plain sentences** create urgency and intimacy.)

Q18. [2] — Why women cry more often

1 mark each for any two of:

- **Hormonal:** testosterone (more abundant in men) **suppresses** tear production.
- **Hormonal:** prolactin (more abundant in women) **encourages** tear production.
- **Cultural:** boys are taught from early childhood that crying is **shameful**, while girls are not.

Q19. [2] — Gap “almost vanishes” in egalitarian countries

1 mark — It suggests the gap is **largely caused by culture / social expectation**, not by biology alone — where the rules about gender are less strict, men and women cry at similar rates.

1 mark — It implies that biology only **partly** explains the difference; **upbringing and social pressure** play a much larger role than was once assumed.

Q20. [1] — Effect of “flood”

1 mark — The word **flood** is a **metaphor**; it suggests that meaning **overwhelms** the brain **suddenly and uncontrollably**, like rising water — appropriately, this excess “overflows” into tears. (Also accept: it links the **abundance of feeling** directly to the **liquid** nature of tears.)

Q21. [2] — Tears as a “message”

1 mark — Describing tears as a **message** is a **metaphor**; it gives tears a **communicative purpose**, as if they carry information from one person to another.

1 mark — **Effective** because it captures the writer’s main argument: tears are not just a biological by-product but a **signal** asking others for **comfort and closeness** — a wordless form of language.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

What scientists believe emotional tears may do (Paragraphs 3, 4, 6):

1. They may **remove stress-related hormones / proteins** from the body — a **chemical** function.
2. They act as a **social signal** — a wordless message that the crier is in distress.
3. They make a face appear **sadder and more sincere**, encouraging others to **offer help / kindness**.
4. They may be triggered by **art or beauty**, when meaning **overwhelms** the brain.
5. They may also reflect being **moved** by something the crier **cannot help or hold**.

Why crying differs between people and cultures (Paragraph 5):

6. **Hormonal differences:** testosterone **suppresses** tears (more in men); prolactin **encourages** them (more in women).
7. **Cultural teaching:** boys are taught crying is **shameful**, while girls are not.
8. The gap is **widest in rigid cultures** and **almost disappears in egalitarian** ones, showing **culture matters more than biology**.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Scientists believe that emotional tears may flush out stress hormones, though this is unproven. More clearly, they act as a wordless plea: a tearful face is judged sadder and draws kindness from

others. Tears also fall before great art, when feeling overwhelms the brain. Crying varies between people because testosterone reduces it while prolactin encourages it, and because boys are taught it is shameful. The gap between men and women is therefore widest in less equal societies.

Length count: 78 words from “Scientists” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —